

Off the Shelf



Grandia II

More than a tale...

Grandia II is a typical fairy tale—complete with a dashing hero and a damsel to escort across unknown and dangerous lands. Try it out after casting away your first impressions, and you will soon discover that a game is seldom to be judged by its appearance. *Grandia II* is anything but a fairy tale.

Gameplay is arguably the most important element that can make or break a game and thankfully, *Grandia II* scores high in this regard. At first glance, you cannot help comparing the combat mechanics with the hugely popular



Final Fantasy series. However, you will discover that the combat system works

quite differently than the seminal games of that series. For example, in *Grandia II*, you can see your enemies in the open and can thus sneak up on them. Of course, turnaround is fair play, and at times, enemy forces will waylay you if you do not observe your surroundings carefully.

Grandia II offers solid graphics, a good story, and great gameplay. Though it's fairly lengthy, like a good RPG ought to be, the ensuing action makes the time fly. By the end of it, you are sure to have a very fulfilling gaming experience.

Genre: Role-playing game ■ **Developer:** Game Arts ■ **Publisher:** Ubisoft ■ **System Requirements:** PII 350, 64 MB RAM, 16 MB VRAM, DirectX 8.0 ■ **Phone:** 022 - 8381614 ■ **Web site:** www.ubisoft.com
Rating: ★★★★★



Charlie's Angels: Angel X

X misses the spot

The *Charlie's Angels* franchise is well liked for the over-the-top shenanigans of a cloth-deprived trio of femme fatales. Surprisingly, none of those strengths are carried over to this game. None of the movie's principal characters appear in the game and the soundtrack tends to be repetitive.

Angel X's high points are the basic punch attack and some special moves to despatch a steady stream of enemies. Gain more strike moves as the game progresses, but since those that oppose you are just as mechanical as yourself, these are not really needed. The AI has been schooled to punch as fast as possible, and the best answer to that frame of existence is to



counter-punch faster than what's possible.

Missions are not novel in any manner and involve either simplistic puzzles,

or dull path-finding chores. The game is also quite buggy in many departments. The collision engine (whose presence is suspect), registers hits with the alacrity of a government tube-light.

The tacky menu interface offers more challenges. Controlling the Angel with the mouse is quite a feat. Angel X will frequently run into walls, doors and sundry surfaces; and attacking an enemy is a frustrating battle between you and the mouse.

Thanks to the sorry engine, the game looks like a retired Angel. The pixel-clear graphics lend a rough and unfinished look to the product. To sum up, the game is not worth trying out.

Genre: Action/Strategy ■ **Developer:** 7 Studios ■ **Publisher:** Sony Interactive ■ **Distributor:** Sony Interactive ■ **System requirements:** Microsoft Windows 98 SE, ME, 2000, or XP, PIII 733 or equivalent, 128 MB RAM, 100 MB hard disk space, Direct X compatible 3D video card with 32 MB RAM, DirectX 8.1 ■ **Price:** \$19.99 (Rs 920) ■ **Web site:** www.sonypictures.com/movies/charliesangels2/game
Rating: ★☆☆☆☆